

SKILLS OF THE FUTURE



FUTURE OF WORK IN FINANCIAL SERVICES: ADAPTATION AND AUTOMATION

It's no secret that artificial intelligence (AI) is set to dramatically reshape the workforce soon.

According to recent findings from Accenture, we're looking at up to 30% of tasks in financial services becoming automated in the next two years, with technology augmenting up to 48% of tasks. Meanwhile, a significant 39% of the financial services workforce is now embracing flexible work arrangements, either working entirely from home or choosing when to come into the office. These developments have profound implications for team dynamics, leadership styles, and organizational culture.

As we navigate through these transformative times, it becomes increasingly clear that we must enhance those skills that are inherently human – such as creative problem-solving. These skills are complementary to AI technologies, enabling firms within the financial sector to innovate, adapt, and thrive in the digital era.



COMMUNICATION

Communication remains paramount. In an era where AI has the capacity to generate reports, analyse data, and even prepare draft emails, the importance of effective communication might seem diminished. However, the reality is quite the opposite. AI lacks the ability to truly understand the nuances of human interaction, making effective communication essential for fostering collaboration, building trust, and ensuring that ideas and strategies are both understood and supported. Skills in presentation, networking, and facilitation are increasingly vital for both team and organizational effectiveness.



Moreover, the ability to influence is gaining importance. This involves advocating for the ethical use of AI, leading organizational changes prompted by automation, and convincing stakeholders to adopt new technologies. Effective influencing requires a deep understanding of human psychology, empathy, and the capability to present a vision that is both compelling and motivational. This skill is not about manipulation but rather about inspiring and motivating others to recognize the benefits of AI, while also addressing any concerns and resistance.

EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

Closely linked to influencing is **Emotional Intelligence (EI)**. EI – the capacity to be aware of, control, and express one’s emotions, and to handle interpersonal relationships judiciously and empathetically – is crucial. As automation and AI continue to advance, the human capacity for emotional connection and the building of strong relationships becomes irreplaceable and will only increase in value.



Leadership, too, must evolve. The ability of leadership teams to guide their organizations through change, fostering resilient and adaptable teams, is paramount. This requires openness to acquiring new skills, re-evaluating traditional approaches, and responding effectively to the changing demands of the workplace. Without proactive leadership, organizations may face a stagnant culture, potentially leading to talent migration to more forward-thinking competitors.

Creativity is now essential for organizational vitality. While AI can refine and enhance existing concepts, it is less adept at generating completely new ideas. This is where human creativity becomes crucial. It’s about thinking differently, asking “what if,” and pushing the boundaries of possibility. In a landscape dominated by data and automation, creativity distinguishes businesses, driving innovation and novel solutions. This requires not only logical reasoning but also the foresight to anticipate challenges, evaluate various options, and make decisions that are ethical and aligned with long-term goals.



TECHNICAL SKILLS

In addition to these softer skills, a new set of **technical skills** is becoming increasingly necessary. Data analytics, machine learning, AI, big data, and extended reality are areas where many financial services firms find themselves lacking. Keeping up with these rapidly evolving fields requires an agile approach to learning and development.

As knowledge and skills rapidly evolve, **hiring for skill over experience** becomes more crucial. Emphasizing diversity of thought is also key, as creative, diverse teams are more likely to succeed in the new work landscape. Maintaining **psychological safety** is essential to maximizing the benefits of a diverse workforce.

Learning and development strategies must also evolve, with a focus on team-based learning and leveraging social learning tools to foster a sense of belonging, particularly in a remote or automated work environment. Personalized learning approaches, such as executive coaching, are increasingly important for skill development and team cohesion.

The future of work promises significant change, but it offers a vision where humans engage deeply with tasks that highlight their unique strengths. Some firms will emerge more productive, with a happier and more fulfilled workforce. Others may struggle to keep pace. The question remains: where will your company stand?

For those seeking to enhance key future skills like effective communication, fostering psychological safety, and creative problem-solving, Hatwell Group provides targeted training and one-on-one coaching. Our programs are designed to help leadership teams evolve their skills to meet both current and future demands. Contact us for more information.



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